

Sridhar Iyer, associate professor, Dept. of Computer Science, IIT Bombay, talked about two case studies of a FOSS set up in the institution, Project Oscar and Project Ekalavya. These projects opened the students' eyes to the benefits of FOSS and also trained them in developing software in open source, he said.

"Flexibility is the key benefit of FOSS apart from the low cost associated with it. Also, open source facilitates creativity in the students, since they can directly put their ideas into practice as there is no upfront cost, proprietary rights and copyrights associated in the initial set up," said D. Janakiram, Department of Computer Science, IIT Madras. And in the educational scenario, open source provides an immense opportunity to develop software, right from designing it to offering support.

The panel discussion on 'Adopting FOSS in education—The road ahead' was chaired by Dr M Sasikumar, associate director (research), CDAC, Mumbai. He said that compared to other industries, only in the IT industry was the 'raw material' vendor specific. This creates problems for academia, since they cannot concentrate on one area. He also said that industry and academia should join hands together to promote open source and to solve the problems associated with it. C.N. Krishnan, program director, MIT Campus, Anna University, said that in the present education scenario 85 per cent of the curriculum concentrates on theories, and only 15 per cent on practical aspects, while open source is all about 'practicalities'. So there should be a revamp in the curriculum.

FOSS For Everyone

The final day of the seminar was dedicated to the idea of 'FOSS for Everyone'. Boudhayan Gupta, a fourteen-year-old FOSS fanatic, spoke on how he fell in love with FOSS. He said that FOSS actually makes more sense because we live in the age of Liberty, Equality, Freedom and Fraternity, and FOSS gives us all those rights. He also said that FOSS offers the freedom to do whatever you want to with the software, such as take it apart, hack it, and all without being restricted in any way either legally or financially.

Gautam Sinha, CTO, Times Business Solutions, spoke on why TBS chose FOSS over proprietary solutions. He said that FOSS itself is a powerful word, which has two strong words in it, 'free' and 'open'. "We were working with proprietary software and we didn't have too many issues with it. But when we moved to FOSS we had advantages over cost and our productivity also increased," he said. He added that the heavy traffic of TimesJobs.Com, which has a database of ten million users, and SimplyMarry.com is smoothly managed by FOSS software, with sub-five second response times for each query.

The Chennai LUG initiated a panel discussion on the topic 'Free as in Freedom Distros'. Bharati, a member of the Chennai LUG, said that if you choose proprietary software, you have only different versions of one product like Windows 98, Windows XP, Windows Vista and so on, but if you opt for open source, you have a variety of choices like Ubuntu, Fedora, Gentoo, Mandriva, BOSS and so on. The panellists presented the case of each of these distros, one by one.

Krish Ashok, head, TCS Innovations Lab—Web 2.0, shared a presentation outlining the Open Source movement that's slowly gaining momentum within TCS. Apparently, they plan to launch a corporate blog very soon, which is going to be based on Joomla. And as we all know now, the brand new website of the Tata Nano has also been developed on the same CMS.

The event also witnessed the

Another team mate of ours, ALFY's official Tweeter, is obsessed with his newly acquired BlackBerry. While he was live tweeting from his phone, he had no idea about his surroundings. Once, he was too busy to get his hand baggage tagged by the security and had to rush back, at the very last minute, while the whole plane was waiting for him before the take-off.

entertaining and thought provoking talk by red1 (that's Redhuan D. Oon, the chief developer of the Adempiere ERP Suite) who jokes that he is the next Linus Torvalds-cum-RMS from Asia. He criticised developers who try to keep control of their projects by stealing the bug reports filed by others. To quote this outspoken gentleman, "If I submit a bug fix, he will say, 'Oh I saw it, it's not good'. And then he will peep into my code, rewrite it and publish it as his own code, stating now that it's perfect." He also said that you need not worry about some open source project being made closed source in the future, because once the code has been GPLed, you cannot close it. Of course, subsequent versions can have a closed licence, but you can always fork the last GPL version and continue development as a separate project yourself.

"So may the fork be with you!" That was his 'call to arms' during dinner, too!

Conclusion

The event, by our standards, truly rocked as we succeeded in bringing together different audiences and we believe everyone benefited from all the interactions. The time schedules were tight, but we managed to pack in a whole lot, in the short period of time. What we've been able to bring to you is just some of what happened. You need to be *right there* to soak in the infectious energy and buzz around open source. *That's* not transferable to newsprint! 

Authors

Swapnil Bhartiya, K T P Radhika and Boudhayan Gupta. Sayantan Pal, Jesus Milton Rousseau and Atanu Datta contributed to the article. Free As In Beer, Too! Only

On our last day in Chennai, right after the conclusion of OSI '09, we met a college student who had no idea about open source before he'd attended the event. He showed us a journal that he had filled up with actual notes of the whole event. He planned to create a presentation for his college mates who'd missed OSI. We fear, he could have given you a better account of the sessions than we have managed to, in this issue. :p